EXCEL

If You Can't Answer These 15 Excel Questions, You're Not Interview Ready

15 questions asked in data analyst Excel rounds, each with the answer and the formula. Try each one before reading the answer.

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Questions 1 to 3

Lookups. Asked in almost every Excel round.

1. Find a value to the LEFT of the lookup column

VLOOKUP cannot look left. Use XLOOKUP or INDEX MATCH.

```
=XLOOKUP(E2, C:C, A:A, "Not found")
```

2. VLOOKUP returns #N/A but the value is visible

Hidden spaces or a number stored as text on one side.

```
=VLOOKUP(TRIM(E2), A:C, 2, FALSE)
```

3. Find the LAST matching value, like the latest price

XLOOKUP with search mode -1 searches from the bottom.

```
=XLOOKUP(E2, A:A, C:C, , 0, -1)
```

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Questions 4 to 6

Conditional totals. The base of every Excel report.

4. Total sales for North in March only

SUMIFS takes the sum range first, then pairs of range and condition.

```
=SUMIFS(Sales, Region, "North", Month, "Mar")
```

5. Count orders above ₹10,000 that are Delivered

COUNTIFS with a comparison inside quotes.

```
=COUNTIFS(Amount, ">10000", Status, "Delivered")
```

6. Average order value, ignoring zero orders

AVERAGEIFS skips rows that fail the condition.

```
=AVERAGEIFS(Amount, Amount, ">0")
```

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Questions 7 to 9

Unique values, ranking and duplicates.

7. Count unique customers

UNIQUE returns the list, COUNTA counts it.

```
=COUNTA(UNIQUE(B2:B500))
```

8. Rank salespeople within their region

COUNTIFS counts how many in the same region have higher sales, plus 1.

```
=COUNTIFS(Region, A2, Sales, ">"&C2) + 1
```

9. Flag duplicate invoice numbers

Any count above 1 is a duplicate.

```
=IF(COUNTIF($A$2:$A$500, A2) > 1, "Duplicate",
"")
```

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Questions 10 to 12

Dates and text. Real data always needs these.

10. Convert 20261107 into a real date

Split the number into year, month and day.

```
=DATE(LEFT(A2,4), MID(A2,5,2), RIGHT(A2,2))
```

11. Working days between order and delivery

NETWORKDAYS skips weekends. Add a holiday range as the third argument.

```
=NETWORKDAYS(B2, C2)
```

12. Extract the domain from an email

Take everything after the @.

```
=TEXTAFTER(A2, "@")
Older Excel: =MID(A2, FIND("@",A2)+1, 100)
```

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Questions 13 to 15

Pivots, dynamic lists and debugging. These show real experience.

13. Show each region's share of total sales in a pivot

Value Field Settings → Show Values As → % of Grand Total. No formula needed.

14. A top 5 products list that updates itself

SORTBY orders by sales, TAKE keeps the first 5.

```
=TAKE(SORTBY(Product, Sales, -1), 5)
```

15. SUM shows 0 but the cells have numbers

Numbers stored as text, calculation set to Manual, or a circular reference. Fix: Data → Text to Columns → Finish, and Formulas → Calculation Options → Automatic.

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How to use these 15

Knowing the formula is half. Explaining your choice is what interviewers score.

- **Practise on one dataset**

  Sales data with date, region, product, customer, amount, status. All 15 work on it.

- **Say why, not just what**

  "I used XLOOKUP because the return column is to the left, and it handles not-found cleanly."

- **Know the older version too**

  Some companies still use Excel 2016. Know INDEX MATCH and MID-FIND alternatives.

- **Score yourself**

  12+ without looking: ready. 8-11: one more week. Below 8: start with questions 1-6.

Version note: XLOOKUP, UNIQUE, TEXTAFTER, SORTBY and TAKE need Excel 365 or Excel 2021+ (TEXTAFTER and TAKE need 365).

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